Sheik Datu Ramos Saripada

Sheik Datu Ramos Saripada was an influential Maranao traditional ruler who made history as the first Municipal President of the Municipal District of Watu — the seat of governance for a territory known today as the Municipality of Balindong in Lanao del Sur, Mindanao.

He lived and led during one of the most complicated chapters of Philippine history: the American colonial period, when foreign administrators were trying to bring the fiercely independent communities of the Lanao region under a centralized government.

Saripada didn't simply accept that role — he shaped it. He served as a living bridge between two very different systems of authority: the centuries-old customary law of the Maranao known as *taritib*, and the formal bureaucratic structure the Americans were building across the archipelago. That balance defined his legacy.

His administration is most vividly documented through a letter he received from Theodore Roosevelt Jr. — then Governor-General of the Philippines and eldest son of the 26th U.S. President — a document that his family managed to preserve through war, occupation, and the upheaval of the mid-20th century.

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Historical Context: Lanao Under American Rule

When the Americans took hold of the Philippines in the early 1900s, they quickly realized that governing the Moro Province — and Lanao in particular — wasn't going to work the same way it did elsewhere in the archipelago.

The Maranao had their own systems, their own rulers, and their own deeply rooted sense of how communities should be run. The Americans weren't going to simply overlay a foreign structure on top of all that without consequence.

So instead of forcing the issue head-on, colonial administrators tried a different approach. The major trade centers of the region — places like Iligan and Dansalan (now Marawi City) — were organized as standard municipalities. But most of the Lanao region was divided into 30 distinct Municipal Districts, each one meant to respect the local character of the communities within it.

The Policy of Attraction

At the heart of this approach was what American administrators called the "Policy of Attraction." The idea was straightforward: rather than displacing traditional leaders, the colonial government would bring them into the fold by giving them formal positions within the new administrative system.

This meant reaching out to the most respected sultans and datus in each area — the men whose authority their communities already recognized — and appointing them to lead the newly created municipal districts.

Saripada was one of those leaders. His appointment as Municipal President of the District of Watu wasn't a coincidence or a consolation prize — it was a deliberate choice by colonial administrators who understood that stability in Lanao depended on working with leaders the Maranao people already trusted.

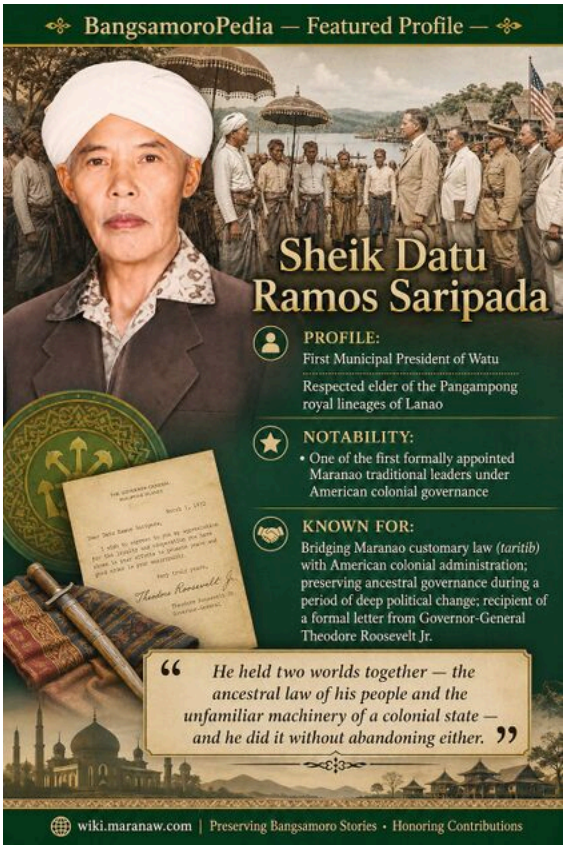
The arrangement gave Saripada legal authority within the colonial state. But he brought something to the role that no appointment letter could confer: the customary legitimacy and the personal standing he had earned among his own people.

Administration of the Municipal District of Watu

The territory Saripada governed — the Municipal District of Watu, also recorded historically as *Uatu* or *Wato* — was situated in the undivided province of Lanao, in the heart of Maranao country.

As Municipal President, Saripada held a dual mandate. On paper, he was an officer of the colonial government, accountable to the American administrative chain of command. In practice, he was also the custodian of his community's traditions and the guarantor of a way of life that long predated the American arrival.

Managing both of those roles at once, without letting one swallow the other, was the real work of his administration. Under Saripada's stewardship, Watu remained deeply rooted in Maranao cultural identity — connected to the foundational royal lineages known as the *Pangampong* of Lanao, the ancestral networks that gave the region its social and political structure.

Sheik Datu Ramos Saripada

Title / Position
Municipal President, Municipal District of Watu
Jurisdiction
Municipal District of Watu (now Balindong, Lanao del Sur)
Period
American Colonial Period, Moro Province
Ethnicity
Maranao
Region
Lanao, Mindanao, Philippines
Traditional Standing
Datu; respected elder of the Pangampong royal lineages of Lanao
Notable Archival Record

The Theodore Roosevelt Jr. Letter

The most significant piece of archival evidence that survives from Saripada's time in office is a formal typed letter, dated July 27, 1932, issued directly from the Office of the Governor-General in Manila.

The author was Theodore Roosevelt Jr. — the eldest son of U.S. President Theodore Roosevelt, and at that time serving as Governor-General of the Philippines.

The letter formally addressed Saripada as the Municipal President of "Uatu" and extended the Governor-General's official gratitude for the hospitality and reception that Saripada had organized during Roosevelt Jr.'s official tour of the Lanao region.

It was, in the language of the era, a formal acknowledgment from the highest colonial authority in the Philippines to a Maranao datu — a moment that captured, in a single document, just how central figures like Saripada were to the colonial government's strategy in the region.

Official correspondence from Governor-General Theodore Roosevelt Jr., dated July 27, 1932
Notability
First Municipal President of the Municipal District of Watu (now Balindong, Lanao del Sur); one of the first formally appointed Maranao traditional leaders under American colonial governance
Known For
Bridging Maranao customary law (taritib) with American colonial administration; preserving ancestral governance during a period of deep political change; recipient of a formal letter from Governor-General Theodore Roosevelt Jr.
Pull Quote
"He held two worlds together — the ancestral law of his people and the unfamiliar machinery of a colonial state — and he did it without abandoning either."

A Document That Survived the War

What makes the letter even more remarkable is what happened to it afterward.

The physical document carries a series of handwritten annotations marked "Noted," written at different points between 1934 and 1948. One of those signatures, dated 1943, belongs to a Lieutenant Colonel of the 108th Division.

That date is significant. 1943 was deep inside the Japanese occupation. The fact that the letter was being annotated and preserved during that period tells a story of its own: Saripada's family chose to hold onto this record through one of the most dangerous and disruptive periods in Philippine history, carrying it through war and into the early years of postwar reconstruction.

That act of preservation speaks to how much the document meant — not just as a piece of paper, but as proof of a man's standing and his community's place in a larger story.

Legacy and the Birth of Balindong

Saripada's time as Municipal President planted roots that lasted well beyond his own era. Watu continued as an anchor of traditional Maranao culture through the American period and into the Commonwealth years, its connection to the *Pangampong* lineages keeping its identity intact through the changes that came with each new administration.

In 1956, that chapter closed and a new one opened. Under Republic Act No. 1424, the Municipal District of Watu was formally elevated and renamed the Municipality of Balindong — a name honoring a prominent ancestral ruler of the area and recognizing the community's deep historical roots.

The transformation from colonial district to independent municipality was, in a sense, the completion of what Saripada's administration had helped to protect: a community that navigated colonial rule without losing itself.

Descendants and Continuing Legacy

Saripada's legacy didn't stay frozen in the past. His modern descendants have remained active in Philippine history, in law, and in local sports — people who carry forward a family story that stretches back to one of the Lanao region's most consequential periods of political transition.

They also continued what their ancestor started: preserving the records. The Roosevelt Jr. letter and other archival materials from Saripada's era have been kept across generations, making it possible to document and tell this story today.

Recognition

Saripada's historical significance rests on several intersecting contributions:

His appointment as the first Municipal President of Watu made him a pioneer of Maranao participation in formal governance structures during the colonial era. His ability to hold traditional authority and colonial responsibility in balance offered a model for how indigenous leadership and outside administration could coexist — even if imperfectly. And the survival of the Roosevelt Jr. letter, with its multi-decade trail of annotations, gives historians a rare primary source that illuminates the texture of colonial-era governance in Lanao.

Together, these pieces of his life add up to a portrait of a man who led with both roots and reach.

See Also

- Balindong, Lanao del Sur
- Maranao people
- Moro Province
- Theodore Roosevelt Jr.
- Lanao del Sur
- American colonial period in the Philippines

External Links

- Source of basic data and photos - **Pangnal Datu Ramos** (https://www.facebook.com/pangnaldaturamos45/posts/pfbid0dMRJisj3KWHZEh8MtssmZUtYciRmo6iebP8xne3RR8jETFggNv5DAGHhqj3FQTYJl)

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